

side in the competition. The batting had depth. The bowling had variety. The fielding remained sharp.

More than anything else, there was a sense of calm. **Kohli** acknowledged it after the final. "I said to a few other boys that it doesn't feel like the same pressure as last year."

We knew what kind of ability we had in the group. We topped the table. There's a reason we got here first, and we just said one thing: if we stick to our cricket, if we execute our plans, we are the best team in the comp, and there's a reason why we have done well so far in the group stage," Kohli said.

The final felt like an extension of everything RCB had done during the league phase. There were no tactical surprises and no signs of a side overwhelmed by the occasion. The bowling laid the platform. The fielders sustained the pressure, and the batters tightened the screws.

RCB simply played the same brand of cricket that had carried it to the top of the table. The occasion had changed. The approach had not.

Long after the presentation ceremony ended, many of the players were still on the field.

Kohli lingered near the boundary rope, soaking in the atmosphere. Patidar moved from one television interview to another. Members of the support staff gathered around the trophy for photographs they would probably revisit years from now. Even as the stadium slowly emptied, nobody seemed particularly eager to leave.

For a franchise that spent nearly two decades waiting for its first IPL title, nights like these remain precious.

A year ago, RCB finally got rid of the baggage that had followed it for years. Twelve months later, it had returned to the summit. The wait for one trophy lasted 18 seasons. The second took only a year.

And as the celebrations rolled on deep into the Ahmedabad night, there was a growing sense that this team was no longer chasing history. It was creating a new one.

Proof, by numbers



3

RCB became only the third franchise in IPL history to successfully defend its title, joining Chennai Super Kings (2011) and Mumbai Indians (2020).



4

Virat Kohli became the first player with 600+ runs in four consecutive IPL seasons.



1

Rajat Patidar became the first captain to win the IPL in each of his first two seasons in charge. He is only the third skipper overall to claim back-to-back titles, after MS Dhoni (2010, 2011) and Rohit Sharma (2019, 2020).



5-0

Krunal Pandya's record as a player in IPL finals. Only Rohit Sharma and Ambati Rayudu, with six wins each, have been part of more victorious IPL finals.



28

Wickets taken by **Bhuvneshwar Kumar** in IPL 2026, equalling the second-highest tally by an Indian in a single season. Only Harshal Patel's 32 wickets in 2021 rank higher.